

vying for your attention and the ensuing competition among brands, it's a healthy marketplace, ripe with choices for the customer. But with the wider playing field arises the problem of plenty, and far from being spoilt for choices it's sometimes downright confusing when it comes to deciding which platform or operating system you should consider on your smart device. That's where we come in.

Laptops & Hybrids

As far as laptops, ultrabooks, hybrids or 2-in-1 tablet-laptop devices go, the choices aren't too many and Windows continues to dominate these form factors. You might come across cases like the Microsoft Surface Pro and Surface RT devices, if at all you count them as hybrid device; given the difference in hardware between the Microsoft Surface Pro (an x86 device) and Surface RT (an ARM device), you may find differing versions of Windows (Pro and RT, in all likelihood), but that still counts as a differing flavour of Windows and you're still tied down to Microsoft's ecosystem. The early ASUS Transformer devices all embraced Android as the platform of choice, the first few clamshelled hybrids to do so.

At Computex 2013, we saw what ASUS claims to be the first device to run Android and Windows 8 simultaneously, the Transformer Book Trio -- which houses an Intel Core processor in its detachable keyboard (with support for Windows) and an Intel Atom processor on its screen / tablet part (supporting Android). But we expect such products to be few and far in between, giving you the choice of two different OSes (platforms) on purchase. Bottom line, as far as laptops and ultrabooks go, even hybrids for the most part, you're stuck with Windows 8.

As long as it's a traditional x86 notebook, nothing stops you from installing a flavour of Linux or even an unofficial Mac OS X on your ultrabook -- the rules of engagement in this case are the same old. But wherever you have a hybrid laptop running a flavour of Android or Windows RT, switching to a different OS may not be as clear cut, and the greatest detriment towards indulging in such an act would be the impending fear of voiding the device's warranty.

Tablets & Smartphones

While we restrict ourselves to only devices based on the ARM architecture, which constitutes almost all smartphones and tablets, the biggest battle rages between iOS and Android. Both are extremely popular platforms,